1 RUNNING THE GAME

A 30-minute homesteading simulation. Groups try to "prove up" a claim by surviving 1884 to 1888.

RUN OF SHOW

1. **Open the board** on the projector (ethomasclass.github.io/plainsfarmer, "Run a Class Game"). Groups join with the 5-letter code.
2. **Pick a mode.** Teacher-Paced: you draw one card for everyone. Self-Paced: each group draws its own.
3. **Press Start.** Teach the Homestead Act panels (60 to 90 seconds).
4. **Setup (3 min).** Groups pick land, a house, and extras.
5. **Five years (about 4 min each).** Spring: plant. Summer: chance card. Fall: harvest. Winter: pay the bank.
6. **Debrief (5 min).** The board tallies the endings and shows 3 questions.

Pacing tip: In Teacher-Paced mode, the board shows "4 of 6 families ready." You do not have to wait. Anyone not done is locked in automatically, and unplanted land stays empty, which is historically fair.

HOW THE MONEY WORKS

- Every family starts with a **$600 bank loan** already in its cash.
- **Spring:** planting costs $20 a plot ($30 for cattle).
- **Fall:** each plot sells for a base price (wheat $54, corn $46, oats $39, cattle $52), changed by the card and the family's choices.
- **Winter:** $300 for food and fuel plus 10% interest on the loan.
- **Short on money?** Sell bison bones (pays less each time), mortgage animals and tools (+$200 now, +$250 owed), or go back east.

THE FOUR ENDINGS

Proved Up and Debt-Free	Survived 5 years with enough cash to pay off the bank. About 15% of games.
Proved Up, Still in Debt	Kept the land but still owes the bank. The most common ending (about 55%).
The Bank Took the Farm	Ran out of options in winter (about 30%).
Went Back East	The group chose to give up.

THE FAMILIES

FAMILY	THE HISTORY BEHIND THEM	GAME TRAIT
The Freemans Exodusters	In 1879 thousands of Black Southerners, called **Exodusters**, moved to Kansas to escape violence and the debt of sharecropping after Reconstruction ended. **Nicodemus**, founded in 1877, was an all-Black town on the Kansas plains.	+10% on every harvest (neighbors work together).
The Larsens Norwegian immigrants	Railroads and states advertised free land across Europe. Scandinavians settled heavily in Minnesota and Dakota Territory. Immigrants could claim land once they filed to become citizens.	+20% on wheat (experienced wheat farmers).
The O'Briens Union Army veteran	Union soldiers could subtract their time in the Army from the 5 years they had to live on the claim.	Pays half interest (the bank trusts a faster claim).
Hattie Moore Widow homesteader	Any woman who was the head of her family (single, widowed, or divorced) could file a claim. Egg and butter sales were often a farm family's only steady cash.	+$75 every fall, no matter what.

SETUP CHOICES: WHAT THEY TEACH

CHOICE	THE HISTORY	PROTECTS AGAINST
Free claim vs. railroad land	Congress gave railroads huge land grants, which they sold to settlers. Railroad land sat near the tracks and farther east, where more rain fell. Free claims were often farther west and drier.	Railroad land: drought. Free claim: saves $300.
Sod house vs. lumber house	The Plains had few trees, so settlers cut blocks of sod to build walls. Sod houses were warm in winter and did not burn. Lumber had to come in by train and cost money.	Sod: blizzards and prairie fire.
Dry farming tools	Plowing deep and planting seeds low helped crops reach moisture in a dry climate.	Drought.
Windmill and well	Windmills pumped groundwater up from deep wells, making farms possible far from rivers.	Drought (for cattle).
Barbed wire	Joseph Glidden patented barbed wire in 1874. Cheap fencing let farmers fence land without trees, and it ended the open range.	Closed range, killing winter.

2 WHEN A CARD IS DRAWN

The real history behind each chance card, and what to say when it lands.

CARD	WHAT REALLY HAPPENED	IN THE GAME
Good Rains	A run of wet years in the late 1870s and early 1880s led boosters to claim that **"rain follows the plow,"** meaning farming would change the climate. It was false, and the dry years came back.	Every crop +30%. *Ask: "Should a family plan on this?"*
Drought	Dry years starting in 1887 drove thousands of families off claims in western Kansas and Nebraska. Some wagons heading east carried the sign "In God we trusted, in Kansas we busted."	Crops badly hurt, worse out west. Dry farming and windmills help.
Grasshoppers	Rocky Mountain locust swarms in 1874 to 1877 were so thick they blocked the sun and ate crops, clothing, and tool handles. Congress passed relief aid in 1875.	Crops 80% lost. Cattle are safe. *Point out who planted a mix.*
Killing Winter	The winter of 1886 to 1887 killed huge numbers of range cattle. Many big ranches went broke, and the cattle boom ended. It was called the "Great Die-Up."	Cattle hit hard unless fenced. Lumber houses make families sick.
Children's Blizzard	On January 12, 1888, a warm morning turned into a sudden blizzard as children were walking home from school. More than 200 people died across the Plains.	Lumber house: sickness and a $50 doctor bill. Sod house: safe.
Prairie Fire	Dry grass fires could move faster than a horse. Settlers plowed strips of bare earth, called firebreaks, around their homes.	Crops -30%. A lumber house burns ($150 to rebuild).
Wheat Prices Crash	New farms and machines grew more grain than buyers needed, so prices fell through the 1880s and 1890s. Farmers worked harder and earned less.	Wheat -60%. *Link to the Populists later.*
Railroad Rates	Most farm towns had only one railroad, so it could charge what it wanted. Angry farmers formed the **Grange**, and Congress passed the Interstate Commerce Act in 1887.	All income -25%. Nothing protects you, on purpose.
Corn Prices Soar	Corn fed the hogs that supplied meatpackers in Chicago, so corn and hog prices were tied together.	Corn +60%.
Barbed Wire Closes the Range	As farmers fenced the open grassland, ranchers lost free grazing. In Texas, "fence-cutting wars" broke out in 1883.	Unfenced cattle -60%. Fenced cattle +20%.
Hailstorm	Summer hail could flatten a whole field in minutes.	Wheat and oats -50%, corn -20%.
Banks Raise Interest	Western farmers borrowed from banks back East, often at high rates, and many lost their farms when they could not pay.	+$50 on the winter bill.
"Surplus" Indian Land	The **Dawes Act** (1887) split reservations into small family plots and sold the "extra" land to settlers. Native land fell from about 138 million acres to about 48 million by 1934. The Oklahoma Land Run opened former Indian Territory on April 22, 1889.	Only drawn in Year 3 or later. Claim 4 more plots for $100. *Ask: "Whose land was this?"*

BISON BONES

Hide hunters killed millions of bison in the 1870s and early 1880s, many shot from trains. Plains nations such as the Lakota depended on the herds for food, clothing, and shelter. Homesteaders gathered the bones left behind and sold them by the ton to be ground into fertilizer. Each sale in the game pays less, because the bones ran out.

WHY STUDENTS DON'T PLAY NATIVE FAMILIES

Native people appear through the cards, the bison bones, and the Dawes Act choice. Students make the settlers' choices and then weigh who paid the cost. That sets up the closing question: "Did Manifest Destiny fulfill its promise, and for whom?"

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

- **The code won't connect:** on the board, click "Use No-Connection Mode." Groups type the 4-digit code, and you reveal each card's unlock word.
- **A student reloads or loses Wi-Fi:** open the same link. Their family is waiting under "Already joined?"
- **Class ends early:** click "Save / Load Class," name it (for example, Period 2), and save. Tomorrow, open it and groups rejoin with the same code.
- **A group is stuck in winter:** they must pay, sell bones, mortgage, or give up. If you advance, the game picks for them.
- **"Is the game rigged?"** Yes, a little, like the real Plains. About 4 in 10 real claims proved up.

Sources: National Archives, "Homestead Act (1862)"; National Park Service, Homestead National Historical Park; Library of Congress.